Pakistan for it was a neighbouring Islamic country that gave refuge to hundreds and thousands of Afghans and supported the Taliban in the 1990s. As for Indian worries of the Taliban supporting fighters in Kashmir, Mujahid clarified that there were no links between the Taliban and the LeT, and the Taliban had never taken part in any attack in India, nor will it do it at Pakistan's behest. The tone of Mujahid's message, however, was eerily similar to that of Muttawakil, Jaleel, and Zaeef's interviews describing India's Afghanistan policy in the mid and late 1990s and that of Massoud in 1992. Though India's role was different from the big powers that 'occupy' Afghanistan, it was far from neutral. Allegedly, during a battle in Khost, the Taliban found Indians in civilian clothes fighting alongside the Afghan National Army.[102] It was an old allegation that many Mujahideen (and Taliban) elements had made since mid-1980s, without evidence. The real problem, however, was India's lack of acceptance of the Afghan Taliban as a legitimate political movement. In 2013, India responded to this specific grievance by allowing Zaeef to participate in the *Tehelka* magazine's festival in Goa called *Think*.[103] Zaeef had been introduced to Indian intelligence officials during his visit to London in 2011, where he had participated in a similar conclave at King's College London. Two years later when the question of granting him a visa for the festival emerged, the R&AW backed his case strongly.[104]

The Afghan Taliban and the Hizb-e-Islami were interested in engaging with India for domestic political reasons. Having built goodwill across Afghanistan, India was the only country that could work as a credible counter-weight against Pakistan and also increase their domestic political value vis-à-vis Karzai and former United Front leaders. According to Sanaullah Tasal, an Afghan security analyst at the Bacha Khan Foundation, who worked closely with the Americans and knew the internal dynamics of the Hizb-e-Islami, the Afghan Taliban, and the Kabul government extremely well, Hekmatyar took Pakistan's support despite being frustrated and disillusioned with the ISI because no other country was willing to support him.[105] The Indians for the most part, from his standpoint, were simply afraid of opening up to Hekmatyar based on a false belief that he was still an ISI crony. 'One thing that I always blame India from [sic] when I meet with them [Indian officials in Afghanistan] is, why are you not reaching to these people [Hizb-e-Islami]? Why are you always suspicious of them? Massoud,